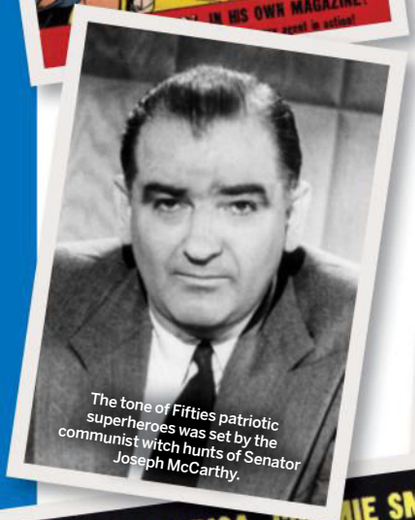




The tone of Fifties patriotic superheroes was set by the communist witch hunts of Senator Joseph McCarthy.



him." His other explanation lies in the core values of Cap's character: "Not just 'political' values like justice and equality, but also personal virtues like honesty and courage, which people still regard as important and to which they still aspire today."

Cap's new adventures began in 1964, although first Marvel had to undo the unfortunate 'commie-smashing' era of the fifties. Luckily, comics continuity can be over-written by anything from Skrull replacements to simply ignoring stories, and Cap's actions were waved away as the scheme of an imposter. In a narrative conceit particularly suited to comic books, it was revealed that at the very end of World War II, Captain America had actually been frozen beneath the ice during a WWII mission that also apparently claimed sidekick Bucky's life. Thanks to the super-serum, Cap spent the next 20 years living the life of a popsicle. It was a neat trick on the part of Marvel writers: by the time Cap was thawed out, the politics and ideologies that had shaped both him and America had changed. Rather than updating his origin story or simply waving away his dated roots, the writers embraced his archaic, almost quaint worldview. Just as the world between the pages had moved on without Captain America, the comic-buying public had passed the character by. He emerged to worlds real and fictional as a relic of past ideals.

"He was reintroduced to a world when the 'good guys' weren't always good and the 'bad guys' weren't ambiguously bad. He still adhered to his core principles of right and wrong, but discovered that applying those principles wasn't as easy as it seemed to be in the Forties – and, in fact, it had never been as easy as he thought," says White. Dittmer also points out that "the overarching story of Captain America since 1963 has been a 'man out of time', struggling to accommodate himself to the 'new' America in which he finds himself."

This 'new' America provided Cap with lots of conflict. In a fictionalised account of Watergate, Cap faced his biggest encounter with government corruption in his beloved country. Rather than blindly supporting those in power, Cap reacted by throwing off his title as a sign of his disillusionment and taking on another: Nomad – the hero without a country – rose up in his place for a few years.

Social change became a mine for stories, too. Race and gender issues came to the forefront, and the comics industry had to make sure they weren't left behind. Although the African-born Black Panther appeared in 1966, *Captain America* #117 – published in 1969, the year after Civil Rights leader Martin Luther King was shot – saw the first African-American superhero in the Falcon. He and Cap became partners, eventually sharing the cover and title from 1971 until 1978. Rather than ignoring prejudice through Cap's own innate sense of equality, they used it to explore the theme, according to Dittmer: "They turn his colour-blindness against him. The Falcon has to teach him to see the racism at the heart of American culture, because Captain America just doesn't notice it."

The most striking real-world story was 11 September 2001. Seen as an assault on the US itself, it would have been awkward had Captain America not dealt with the terrorist attacks in some way. White sums up Cap's

> "CAPTAIN AMERICA'S PATRIOTISM IS A VERY COSMOPOLITAN PATRIOTISM, AND HE NOT ONLY HOLDS HIS OWN GOVERNMENT TO THOSE IDEALS, BUT HE ALSO DEMANDS THAT THEY BE EXTENDED TO PEOPLE OF EVERY NATION"
> MARK WHITE

